anchorage

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/64267513.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora & Glimmer (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Fluff, Angst, Fluff and Angst, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), catra kinda fucking hates her actually, One-Sided Attraction, One-Sided Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Dubious Morality, glimmers a little snotty and stubborn, Glimmer is a Good Friend (She-Ra), though, Jealous Glimmer (She-Ra), just a bit, A tease, Hurt Adora (She-Ra), Adora Needs a Hug (She-Ra), Love Confessions, Confessions, Drinking, i can't resist making adora an alcoholic, Drinking to Cope, Heavy Drinking, glimmer drinks too but she's basically taking a shot every time adora finishes her glass, POV Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Adora (She-Ra), Lesbian Disaster Adora (She-Ra), Canon Lesbian Character, Lesbian Character, Bisexual Glimmer (She-Ra), Mentioned Catra (She-Ra), okay you get glimbow and glimmadora and catradora as a treat, Dialogue Heavy, glimmer is in love with adora and bow but she does NOT wanna unpack that, all my fics are practically a skewed story of love atp, Love, Falling In Love, technically this has fluff, but its mainly angst, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Childhood Friends, adora isn't the most reliable narrator cause im a sucker for conflicting memories, glimmers such a lightweight, lonnie is a bully, i actually birthed rogelio and kyle they are mine, (im a man), okay catra doesnt hate her shes just complicated, Foreshadowing, slight foreshadowing hidden in one singular line, okay i gotta say this as a preface: lonnie is my favorite character from the squad, i gave birth to kyle a rogelio but i took in lonnie against her will, Adora is in Love with Glimmer (She-Ra), Sex, Drunken Confessions, Drunken Kissing, technically dubcon cause they're both drunk but in the moment, but its not meant to be bad, swear, Lesbian Sex, Drunk Sex, glimmer initiates and adora just kinda follows along because she loves her in a way, fades out before the actual smut bc i dont wanna write it, Intimacy

Language:
English

Series:
Part 3 of Adora Dies (Nothing is the Same)

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Published: 2025-04-21 Words: 4,255 Chapters: 1/1

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by Lukaswritesthings

Summary

"I mean, Catra was my friend, you know? Like, probably the only one I had." She gently reaches out to take the bottle back, making brief eye contact as her fingers graze Glimmer's. The woman huffs with surprise, her grip slackening as she lets Adora take it. With a swig, the blonde speaks again. "I couldn't imagine hurting her when we first met. I couldn't imagine any of this."

A sudden curiosity reaches it's way into Glimmer's eyes, sparkling with intensity. "When did you guys meet anyways? You've mentioned you and her have a history, but how far back does it go?"

or; adora gives glimmer the rundown of how she and catra met over a bottle of stolen whiskey, inadvertently confessing her feelings about the magi-cat. glimmer takes this about as well as you'd expect her to. adora responds in kind.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

anchorage

noun.

"the desire to hold onto time as it passes, like trying to keep your grip on a rock in the middle of a river, feeling the weight of the current against your chest while your elder float on downstream, calling over the roar of the rapids, "Just let go - it's okay - let go.""

"So, you wanted to talk?"

The first words out of Glimmer's mouth are quiet, so quiet that it takes Adora a minute to respond. When she processes what the other woman has asked, she swallows her mouthful of pungent liquid and looks away pointedly.

"You seemed mad at me today." Although Adora says it like it's a statement, it ends up sounding more like another question. Glimmer scowls at the obvious redirection. Especially since this has to be the fifth time Adora's brought it up during the day.

"God, Adora, this again? I told you I wasn't mad at you every time you asked me." Adora shrinks under the sudden annoyance in Glimmer's tone, the whiskey bottle Glimmer had found her with swirling in her hand. Adora hadn't had that much yet, and if they were going to keep talking about this, then Glimmer might take some for herself.

"Every time Netossa brought up the battle plans you kept glaring at me, like I did something wrong. I mean, did I?" Adora takes another drink, only just able to close her mouth before Glimmer snatches the bottle, making Adora yelp and narrow her eyes as the woman takes a large swig. "Hey, that's mine!"

Glimmer shudders as the drink slides down her throat, scrunching up her nose. "No, it's not. It's the kitchen's and you just so

happened to take it."

Adora's sudden bravado disappears as she tilts her head. "How'd you know?"

With a look, Glimmer twists the bottle and Adora can see the Brightmoon logo she'd forgotten was there. "Oh."

Glimmer rolls her eyes. "Yeah, *oh,* idiot." She sighs, eyes watching the whiskey splash against the sides of the bottle. Adora obviously wants to talk, so as much as it despairs her she'll take the conversation seriously. "I guess I was just thinking about Catra. How every time we fight her you, She-Ra, probably the most powerful princess, get her alone, and somehow, she always escapes basically scot-free. Like you don't even put up a fight."

Adora feels her stomach twist at the blatant call-out. Glimmer hadn't asked anything, merely stated an observation, but Adora felt like Glimmer had suggested she lay her soul out, bare it to her for the princess to poke and prod at. It was a disgusting thought, a disgusting suggestion, and Adora felt her face heat up as she realized how eager she was to take it.

"I mean, Catra was my friend, you know? Like, probably the only one I had." She gently reaches out to take the bottle back, making brief eye contact as her fingers graze Glimmer's. The woman huffs with surprise, her grip slackening as she lets Adora take it. With a swig, the blonde speaks again. "I couldn't imagine hurting her when we first met. I couldn't imagine any of this."

A sudden curiosity reaches it's way into Glimmer's eyes, sparkling with intensity. "When did you guys meet anyways? You've mentioned you and her have a history, but how far back does it go?"

"Oh, god." Adora looks up, reminiscing on the earlier years of her life. "Really, it all started when..."

-

Adora feels like a bag of bricks hit her. She'd been running back and forth between the supply boxes and Shadow Weaver's office all day and her weirdly tiny, five year old body aches. It hurts to move, but when she'd complained to Shadow Weaver, the woman had only tutted, shaking her finger and sending Adora on one more run.

"I was basically performing as a mule for Shadow Weaver. I was like, five, six? We had these applesauce supply boxes, really rare by the way, and Shadow Weaver wanted me to take them to her office so she could do inventory. I don't know why she didn't get somebody bigger than me to do it, but still. On the last run, I found her in one of the opened, half empty boxes."

"Her?"

"Catra."

It surprises the young blonde when she finds an even tinier magi-cat kitten curled up in her next box. The child is skinny, definitely underfed, but still sleeping soundly. It's a weird image, to see somebody curled up on a bunch of applesauce containers like they're the best bed in the world. Adora doesn't want to wake her, but if she doesn't, somebody worse will. Though, that's not really her goal when she reaches out to touch her arm. The fur on it just looks so soft.

Just as she's about to make contact, the fur bristles and the kittens eyes jolt open. Her gaze immediately snaps to Adora and she hisses, jumping back. Adora jumps back too, but replaces the hiss with a yell.

"Who are you? Where am I?" The kitten yells, voice high-pitched and gritty. It sounded like she'd been yelling for too long and her vocal chords hadn't been able to keep up.

Adora, still shaking from the sudden loud noises, swallows and stares. The magi-cat, slowly untensing but still watching her every

move, snaps. "What are you looking at? Answer me!" Though she sounds mean, it's hard for the little blonde to be intimidated.

"Your fur looks soft."

"Is that really the first thing you said to her?"

"Oh yeah. I was a kid with a one-track mind. I had a goal and it did not align with Catra's questions, ha."

"... Aren't you drinking that a bit too fast?"

"Huh?'

"... Never mind. Gimme some and keep talking, this is kind of funny."

The kitten, who Adora really needed to learn the name of, looks put-off, completely untensing and tilting her head to give Adora an incredulous look "What?"

Adora reaches a hand out, careful startle her new friend. "Your fur, it looks really soft, can I touch it?"

The kid seems just surprised enough to slowly nod, reaching her own hand out. She shivers as Adora's fingers graze her arm. Adora notices the fur isn't as soft as it looks, it's actually quite crunchy. She can tell it was meant to be soft, though, it was just dirty and covered in grime. The entire kitten was, really.

"What's your name? I'm Adora." She whispers, fingers still making tiny circles on the kittens arm. She's entranced by the foreign feeling of fur against her fingertips.

Kitten, what she's calling her for the second, looks between her and their touching limbs. "They didn't give me one."

"They?" Adora asks on reflex.

Kitten looks away, tearing her arm away from the contact as she does so. As if burned, Adora brings her arm up to her chest, cradling it there. "My parents. I ran away."

Adora hums. Her eyes are glancing away at the walls and pipes as she thinks. "I guess I'll have to give you a name then."

"What?" Kitten repeats her question from earlier, eyes snapping to Adora's reclaiming the blondes attention.

"Yeah!" Adora cheers, a sudden smile on her face. "You don't have a name and I found you, so that makes you mine right?"

It's such a childish line of thinking, an immediate possession that doesn't click for either of them. It just seems right. A personal, real game of finders-keepers that will implant itself in their minds for the rest of their doomed lives.

Kitten shrugs. "Probably? Can I be just mine though?"

Adora shrugs back, copying each of Kitten's mannerisms in a sort of awe. She hasn't had somebody to talk to that's also her age in a while. Shadow Weaver had taken her out of the child's division on the basis that she had some sort of potential, something that needed to be cultivated away from distractions. Adora hadn't really been listening. "I mean, you'll still be mine, but we can share. Shadow Weaver says I'm good at sharing but that I'm not supposed to do it all the time." Adora frowns at the thought but pushes through, ignoring Kitten's question of who Shadow Weaver is. "Names, names, names...":

She gives Kitten a glance before grinning. "What about Catra?" Adora says it with such a flair that Kitten could've believed it to be the best idea she had ever come up with.

"Catra?" Kitten repeats skeptically. The name is easy to roll off her tongue, and it seems to grow on her quickly. "How'd you come up with that?"

Adora's grin grows impossibly wider. She points to Kitten's ears and they tilt downwards at the sudden attention. "Well, you're a cat, or you look like one. Is that mean? I hope not. But, since you're mine, and the last two letters of my name are R and A, I pushed 'em all together and made 'Catra'!"

Kitten, now Catra, gives her a weak glare. "Don't point at my ears!" She seems to dislike the direct way in which Adora had addressed her inhuman nature and, while Adora doesn't really get it, she's not a meanie, so she makes a pact to try not to do it again.

Adora goes to apologize, feeling a slight guilt for making her new friend upset, but she gets cut off.

"Thank you..." Catra mutters. "For the name."

Adora's guilt vanishes and is replaced by a large smile. Like the child with no sense of personal space she is, the blonde leans over and grabs both of Catra's wrists and pulls her close. Catra bristles, baring her teeth, but let's Adora pull her. "Of course! You're my friend now!" Adora giggles, not catching the way Catra's eyes widen and her pupils blow out at the word. "I can't believe I made a new friend from the applesauce boxes!"

As if remembering her job, Adora gasps and pulls away, eyes tearing over the boxes she hadn't unpacked. "Aw, Shadow Weaver is gonna be so mad!" She tears up, not ready to face her mentor empty-handed. Not ready to face disappointment.

Catra's ears twitch and she scrunches her nose. "... Who's Shadow Weaver?"

Adora looks over at her, wiping away the few tears that had fallen. "Oh, I gotta introduce you to her! She's like, really cool and scary but cool!" Every sentence out of her mouth for the past minute had been inches away from a yell, which grates on Catra's ears. She can't find it within her to be mad though, when she's more

confused at the emotional whiplash she's getting from watching Adora change gears so quickly.

The blonde grabs at her hands again, tugging her along. When she returns to Shadow Weaver, it's without the applesauce, and instead with a scrawny kitten at her heels.

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There's silence for a few seconds before Glimmer huffs. "Oh come on, you actually named her?"

Adora nods, as if it's the most normal thing in the world. The whiskey bottle was close to half empty now, mainly due to Adora nursing it through almost every sentence. Her eyebrows are drawn together, and Glimmer wonders if this is a hard topic to talk about. If Adora's just drinking to make it through her story.

Glimmer snickers, tilting her head back. "Oh, god, Adora you named her after *yourself*?"

The blonde's face burns. "No! I mean, kind of?" She smiles tipsily, goofy and uncoordinated. "Can you blame me? I was four!"

Glimmer shoots her a glance, smacking her knee. They'd moved to sit closer to each other, legs almost touching as they curled up together on Adora's bed. "You just said you were five, Adora."

"Sue me."

"How did Shadow Weaver take it? Considering she had you doing manual labor when you were like, five, I can't imagine she's too nice of a person." Glimmer, even drunk, has the sense to not mention what she's heard from her mother.

Adora scoffs, waving it off. "She was a good commander, which was all that mattered. Besides, she was like putty in my hands. One pleading look and Catra was stuck with me forever."

Somehow, Glimmer doesn't believe that. "What happened next?" She asks instead. "You two are obviously close, so..."

Adora looks away, giving Glimmer the chance to admire her. Maybe it's the small amount of alcohol she's put into her system, or just the late time of night finally getting to her, but Adora looks ethereal. Blonde hair pooling around her head like it's flooding out of her, blue eyes glinting with the sliver of moonlight let into the room, and pale, freckled face scrunched up in concentration. Her cheeks have the red hue to them that Glimmer has come to associate with drunkards, but her speech isn't slurred and her body doesn't sway. Adora seems to handle her alcohol well, and Glimmer can't help but find it kind of hot.

"I guess the next big thing would've been us getting put into squads." Adora finally says. "We got put with some kids I remember from the child's division, Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio, but Catra didn't know them at all. I think she considered them threats, or something..."

-

Catra was tense next to Adora, who looked like she didn't have a care in the world. Looked like, being the key term. On the inside, Adora felt like a vase being heated up to it's breaking point.

At ten years old, they were finally being put into squadrons. Lined up, nameless, number tags on their shirts, Adora couldn't help but feel like a piece of meat, waiting to be picked by the butcher. A gruff Force Captain was taking glances at a clipboard and then pointing at cadets, seemingly at random, with a grunt. They'd each go to stand off at the side, grouped together in numbers of four each. Adora felt like just another set of hands to be put to work. However, with Shadow Weaver's gaze on her, and her words still ringing in her ears, she knows she isn't. She's always reminded that she's different somehow.

Finally, the Force Captain pointed to Catra, throwing his thumb back at a group of three. Catra's ears are pinned to her head as

she timidly moves forward. She glances back at Adora, fingers drifting against her own before they're separated by too much space. Adora is suddenly scared.

Something must show on her face because Shadow Weaver, who'd been watching on silently from behind the Force Captain, raised her hand. Although he shouldn't be able to see her, it's almost like the Force Captain can feel a change. He stops, standing up straighter and turning to her.

"Shadow Weaver was like... really good to me for the first few years of my life. This was before Catra started getting really rowdy. Actually, I think she just started getting rowdy because we got put with other people she didn't like that much."

"So, what, she just let you go with her?"

"She's the one who ordered it, actually."

"Place Adora with that squad." It's a simple sentence, but the shadows seem to morph around her as she speaks, tendrils reaching for the clip board. Adora feels compelled to move before the Force Captain even speaks. When he does, though, his eyes are milky. He nods.

"Yes, Shadow Weaver." His eyes snap to Adora eerily. "Cadet, you heard her."

She had. Adora makes quick movements to Catra's side, immediately engulfing her hands with one of her own. Even as they'd grown, Adora had always been bigger than her friend. Catra, who usually hates physical contact like this, leans forward, not quite touching Adora, but the blonde can feel her body heat and it works.

"Oh, so you two were codependent."

"Um... whatever that means, sure. We relied on each other. Six years of knowing each other forges something strong between you, you know?"

".... Yeah. I guess I do."

They'd been in their new squad for roughly two months when things started going wrong. Catra's ration bars started going missing, her blanket was torn to shreds, and she'd wake up to her soap hidden somewhere in the barracks. She was always late to training and she'd even taken to just sleeping in Adora's bed with her because it seemed like nothing touched her. The blonde had been getting the highest marks in every class and training session they'd had, and their teammates loved her. Well, not really loved her, but they tolerated her existence. For Adora, it was everything squads were always said to be. A jumbled, dysfunctional, but tight-knit and protective family. To Catra, it was quickly becoming hell.

"You never noticed what was happening?"

"I dunno... I was young, I guess. Back then, I was a lot more naïve, a-and I was stuck in my own world. Sure, Catra was a part of my world, but she didn't really, talk to me?"

"How much have you drank? Adora, the bottle's almost fucking gone."

"Glimmer, please. We'll just... get ano-another bottle."

"That's not-... fine. Finish your story."

It would be almost five months after when Catra would snap. And it would be in that moment of vulnerability that she gained her first victim.

Training had been especially excruciating to the young kitten. Adora had realized she hadn't seen Catra almost halfway into the session. After asking Lonnie and Kyle, because she couldn't understand Rogelio, Adora realized nobody had seen her. Of course, she hadn't missed the way Lonnie had glanced at the door, or the way Kyle had stammered and shrugged quickly, but they were a squad. Squad's didn't lie.

It would only take a few more minutes for the kitten to show up. And when she did, she was angry. Livid, even.

The simulation shut off, confusing the team of four. Catra burst through the door, a Force Captain behind her. Adora noticed that her hair was sticking up everywhere, and she had red marks on her arms and legs. She growled, eyes scanning the room. The Force Captain shoved her forward with his blaster.

"Cadets!" He called out. It was the same Force Captain that had placed them into squads months before, Adora realized. Quickly, to avoid punishment, they lined up in front of him and Catra and stood at attention. With a pang of confusion and disappointment, Adora saw Lonnie hold back a laugh. She watched Kyle shove the girl until she straightened up.

"Which one of you had the bright idea to tape Cadet Catra up and leave her in a supply closet?"

"Woah, what the fuck? I thought you said you guys were like family?"

"We were. The first few years were kind of... rough. For Catra.":

"I can tell. Taping her up? The marks? Jesus. I can't believe I'm feeling bad for the enemy."

"Okay, it wasn't... they didn't mean for it to happen. Lonnie, Kyle, they were just mischievous. I don't think they actually wanted her to get as hurt as she did."

"Adora, I'm going to take you at your word, but I hope you know how horrid this sounds."

Adora looked between her fellow cadets with surprise and concern. The kitten looked like she had rashes and tape-burn already forming at the end of her limbs, on her ankles and wrists, and her fur seemed to be missing in other places. Adora wondered how long she'd been there, having already been gone by the time the blonde woke up.

"I don't think any of us did, Force Captain." Kyle spoke up. He stuttered and his voice cracked, but he managed to get his thought out. Lonnie nudged him but nodded along with him.

The Force Captain scoffed, poking Catra with his blaster. "Cadet, tell them what you told me."

Catra growled. "Lonnie dragged me out of bed before morning wake up and used Kyle to keep watch while she tied me up and threw me in the closet."

Lonnie bristled. She looked guilty, like a deer in headlights. Kyle flinched and shook.

Adora watched the two with shock and disappointment. Surely, they wouldn't have? She didn't have any reason to not believe Catra, but squads weren't supposed to lie. They weren't supposed to hurt each other either.

"Like hell I did!" Lonnie shouted. "You probably did it to yourself to blame it on me!"

Catra snarled, claws popping out on her hands. "Why would I do that? Give myself tape burns just to be petty?"

Lonnie threw her hands up, getting ready to retort back when the Force Captain yelled.

"Hey! Cut it out." Instantly, the two went silent, glaring at each other. "All three of you will be receiving disciplinary action, starting with cleaning the infirmary bathroom's."

While the three made to protest, Adora tried to reevaluate their squad as a whole. Things from the previous months were coming into light, moments where Lonnie had been too rough or Catra had seemed scuffed up. It was like realizing your family wasn't the heroes they were meant to be.

The next three weeks, Adora watched Catra came back from her new duty, tired and smelling horribly. Now that her scars were

healing and the fur was returning, Adora could admit that it was kind of funny to watch Catra and Lonnie argue about who had to clean the toilets. it was even funnier to watch them somehow always decide on Kyle.

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"Yikes." Glimmer grimaced. "That sounds disgusting."

Adora laughed and nodded, taking another swig of her drink. Glimmer snatched the bottle from her under the guise of taking another drink, meaning to keep Adora from getting more drunk. "Oh yeah, the entire barracks smelled horrible the whole time, but it was still funny."

Glimmer nodded slowly. "You got any other funny stories that don't make me pity Catra?"

Adora hummed, drawing circles on Glimmer's knee where it rested next to hers. "Eh, most of them are much of the same. Catra getting into to trouble, getting caught, and being given some gross punishment. That was most of our childhood really." Adora smiled fondly. "She never lost her spark, though. Catra was always rebellious and cocky. It was so... It was so easy to love her."

Adora didn't seem to notice what she had said, still reminiscing, but Glimmer did. Glimmer stared at Adora with an incredulous look. "You love her?"

Adora stilled her hand from where it had been lazily rubbing against Glimmer's soft skin. She glanced at Glimmer before looking away. "I-I mean, yeah? She's always been so... brave. It's hard not to."

"She's the enemy!" Glimmer exclaimed bitterly. Of course, she'd assumed that Adora felt something more for the magi-cat, but the drunken thickness in her brain was fogging up her senses.

"I didn't... She wasn't to me..."

Glimmer sat up and turned completely to Adora. "How could you still love her, though? After everything? After us?"

"Us?" Adora asked, confusion obvious in her tone.

Glimmer wrapped her hands around Adora's and brought it to her chest. "I *really* like you, Adora. A lo-ot." She hiccupped drunkenly. "I was hoping you'd like me back, y'know."

Adora stared up at her with wide eyes and a flushed face. She kept looking between Glimmer's face, her lips, and their interlocked hands. She licked her lips in a desperate attempt to gain back the moisture she'd lost.

"Glimmer, I..." She trailed off, lost for words. Adora's mind felt hazy, like a fog had taken over. She moved her hand from Glimmer's grasp and trailed it down her side. Did she like Glimmer like that. Did she *love* Glimmer?

"Don't say it." Glimmer pleaded quietly. "Don't tell me you don't feel the same, I already know."

Adora's hand squeezes where it had landed, right above Glimmer's hip. The other woman gasped lowly. It made Adora feel something low in her gut.

"I don't know what I feel." Adora whispered. "I'd... like to find out, though." She doesn't know why she's saying this, or what she means by it, but whatever the case, it seemed to have emboldened Glimmer.

The other woman lifted her leg up and straddled Adora. She trailed her hands up Adora's body and over her chest, stopping at her neck. There was a fiery warmth left behind where she had touched, making Adora close her eyes and groan. When she opened them again, Glimmer was much closer, staring down at her lips.

"Let me show you how I feel, then." Adora gulped and nodded, letting Glimmer press their lips together. It was sloppy at first,

despite it being neither of their first kisses, but they got into the rhythm of it quick enough.

While their lips moved against each other, their hands roamed. Touching each other's chests, hips, thighs, then coming back and slowly undressing their bodies. Adora gasped when she saw Glimmer's bare chest, and the other woman gasped when Adora got even more handsy.

They spent the night like that, exploring each other in a haze. When they woke up the next morning, scantily clad, only one of them remembered what happened. The other, an oblivious blonde, acted like waking up in only your underwear next to a naked woman was normal for friends. And when Glimmer tried to bring it up, Adora said her memory stopped at Glimmer's confession. Glimmer swallowed, nodded, and went along with her day. She never told Adora what they did.

And Adora would never find out.

End Notes

not much to say on this one, i just really wanted to explore how love can skew your perception of things and how it can make you do things you normally wouldn't do. if you're confused on the timeline of things, this'll be after the first scene from "I'll dial drunk, I'll die a drunk," and before the second scene, obviously.
also, im horrible at writing drunken interactions cause i make sure im never drunk around anybody, so if you guys are social drunks yknow, tell me how accurate some of this is

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